

Slow Looking at Street Art: Towards a Design to Guide Discovery, Mindful Observation and Reflection

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Figure 1: A group of young adults practising slow looking at a street mural

Abstract

This exploratory study investigates the practice of slow looking, a prolonged, mindful form of observation, applied to street art. The objective is to understand the perceived value of this activity among young adults living in urban areas to inform the design of a guide that supports this practice. The paper reports a collaborative inquiry to engage critically with slow looking, followed by a cultural probe involving eight participants in multiple activities documented in a journal. Findings indicated that slow looking can enhance engagement with public spaces and offer emotional and social benefits, such as improved mood and shared bonding experiences. Participants also noted challenges, including distractions, discomfort in public settings, and difficulty maintaining focus. These insights underscore the need for structured yet playful design interventions that encourage discovery and connection, guide mindful observation, and trigger self-reflection.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI.

Keywords

Street Art, Cultural Probe, Slow Technology

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1 Introduction

As efficiency, productivity, and instant gratification have become some of the defining characteristics of our fast-paced society, our routines and interactions provide little opportunity for discovery, mindful observation and reflection. Consequently, we tend to miss out on the stories and creativity present in public spaces, such as street art, and lose opportunities to feel a connection with our surroundings.

We align with the *Slow Movement*, which proposes adopting an appropriate pace for different aspects of life, such as food and education, as well as the design and use of technology [4, 5, 12]. *Slow looking* is a related concept focused on prolonged observation, including art, which involves going beyond first impressions to foster more immersive and critical experiences [1, 14]. In this study, we adapt the notion of slow looking as applied in museums¹ and art galleries [1, 11, 14] to street art. Murals and graffiti are aesthetic elements of the city, and the urban landscape shapes how they are perceived and appreciated [8]. As street-based artworks [13], they can carry powerful messages, emotions, and cultural significance. Unlike art in most museums or galleries, they are typically freely accessible.

To start exploring this topic empirically, we conducted an informal observation analysing the time people spent observing street art at a popular tourist attraction in Berlin, where very famous and lesser-known murals share space on the same wall. Of the 88 people tracked, approximately 14% of passers-by stopped, some to observe



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¹Slow Looking at MOMA - <https://www.moma.org/visit/itineraries/slow-looking>

and others to take a photo. On average, they spent just 4 seconds looking at each mural. At the most famous mural², 18% stopped for over 30 seconds, mainly to wait for an opportunity to take a photo rather than to observe. This raises questions about regular, non-touristy locations, where street art is either part of a routine or an unexpected encounter. It is unlikely that observation time would be longer, suggesting a lack of proper engagement with the artworks.

As further described, initiating and immersing oneself in a slow looking process can be challenging due to internal and external factors. Therefore, in this research, we aim to design a guide for slow looking that is suitable for public spaces and encourages discoveries, mindful observations and reflection on the relationship between the observer, street art, and its surroundings.

2 Background and related works

Slow looking aims to extend and deepen observation regardless of its duration [14]. It may lead to a feeling of peace and calm [9, 14], but it requires some structure and guidance. Prompts and questions help the viewer slow down while interpreting and personally connecting with an artwork [11]. Possible strategies include searching for specific characteristics such as colours or shapes; listing all observable features, as an inventory, altering one's physical vantage point; and juxtaposing features with a different objects [14]. Description serves as a cognitive framework for slow looking. It can be about materials, shapes, techniques, perspectives, or more abstract such as adopting a fresh perspective to interpret the artwork from the viewpoint of another persona, whether human or not [14].

Studies exploring slow looking within the context of street art are scarce in current literature. Yet, an eye-tracking based study [2] evidenced that people tend to fix their gaze less and spend less time in the street context, possibly due to distraction opportunities. In addition, these authors found that street art's significance is highly context-dependent and influenced by individuals' interests. Furthermore, street art viewers are more active in interpreting and making their own story of the artwork, in a form of participatory authorship. Responses to street art tend to be positive (a 'delight upon discovery'), though both aesthetic preferences and its potential illegality can lead to negative perceptions instead [6].

This study builds on Mulholland et al. [11], who introduced a web tool using scripts (statements, prompts, and questions) with a slow looking approach to mediate museum visitors' engagement with artworks, democratising the curator's role, especially for underrepresented groups.

3 Methodology

This preliminary study aims to address the perspective of young adults casual city walkers as to answer the questions: *What are the perceived values of slow looking at street art (if any)? What obstacles may prevent people from slow looking at street art? What sort of guidance (prompts or interventions) is more effective to invite and guide people to mindfully observe?*

To gain first-hand experiential insight into the practice, 7 people, including researchers and undergraduate students, participated in

a non-guided, silent slow looking session at a mural for an undetermined duration, as part of a collaborative inquiry activity [7], as illustrated in Fig. 1. Their impressions were later discussed and analysed, offering insights into diverse personal approaches and challenges.

Building on the collaborative inquiry experience, a cultural probe [3] was introduced, guiding participants who were new to the practice to document and reflect on their experience. The cultural probe kit included: a diary with an introductory text about slow looking, prompts for observation following different techniques, including those described in [14], such as searching for shapes, colours or changing viewer's perspectives, prompting personal connections with the art and its surroundings, pages for mindful drawing, and for reflective notes. A map with suggestions for street art spots, and crafting material were also included. Details of the cultural probe set are provided in Appendix A.

Participants were asked to visit 2 to 4 street art locations over 3 weeks. They were asked to use a timer set for each observation task, choosing between 3, 5, 10 or more minutes. Prompts were about describing the artwork according to different visual aspects and perspectives. They were also asked about how the piece interacted with its surroundings, what emotions it evokes, the possible meaning (e.g. *What questions about this work do you have?*), or artist's intention and to connect it with their personal experiences (e.g. *Does anything in the art remind you of something in your life?*). An optional exercise asked to sketch their impressions of the street art, focusing on emotions or elements that stood out. Upon completing all 4 sessions, they recorded their overall reflections on the practice. Post-interviews inquired into the overall experience with slow looking and the cultural probe, with 12 questions including *Would you recommend this activity to others, and if so, why?*, *How might we improve the slow looking activity to make it even more engaging or meaningful for you?*, and *If you could design your own slow looking experience, how would you change the approach or the art involved?* Participants received information sheets and signed consent forms when they received the cultural probe and before the interviews.

4 Results and Discussion

4.1 Collaborative inquiry

The group's engagement naturally extended to approximately 30 minutes of observation, as they continually discovered new details, made connections between visual elements and reflected on their own interpretations, which included depictions of historical periods or personal stories. Individuals noticed distinct aspects such as objects, colours, and style, among others. The group also reflected on their note-taking processes and how their focus shifted during the observation period. The post-activity discussions were recorded, transcribed, and analysed qualitatively to examine their perceptions and feelings throughout the activity.

As described in Fig. 2, the reported experience suggested a slow looking journey starting with curiosity, followed by a process of forming opinions and developing feelings about the artwork. After a few minutes (some participants reported it around 3 minutes), a tipping point was noticed, when viewers felt disengaged, in need of a distraction or another strategy, for example, moving to another viewpoint. After this tipping point, discoveries intensified

²East Side Gallery mural "My God, Help Me to Survive This Deadly Love"

and observations evolved from visual descriptions to personal interpretations, until the viewers felt satisfied or exhausted. The time to reach the stages, though, varied considerably among individuals.

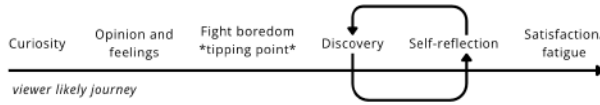
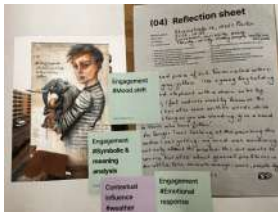


Figure 2: Reported stages of engagement during the collaborative inquiry session mapped as a journey

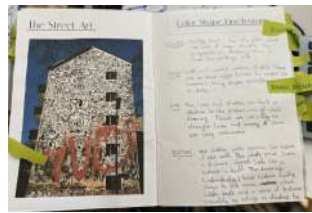
In line with the literature, participants reported projecting personal meanings [2, 6], analysing characteristics, and then shifting perspectives and positions (over time), which led to multiple interpretations [14]. To maintain engagement, participants reported taking notes or drawing: *"started writing a dialogue with myself"* or *"This is not wasting time, but my mind was like, OK, I'm busy, I'm writing down. I'm, you know, not just like standing and wasting time."*

4.2 Cultural probe and interviews

A total of 8 participants (26-37 years old) took part in the cultural probe experiment and follow-up interview. Their notes in the diaries, reflection sheets, and interview transcriptions were qualitatively analysed. The data were first annotated with themes (as illustrated in Fig.3 a and b), such as *noticing details*, *mood shift*, and *influence of the surroundings*, to name a few.



(a) Reflections page of the cultural probe annotated



(b) Observation notes annotated in the physical diary

Figure 3: Cultural probe materials annotated with themes

Next, the data were grouped into the main themes *Types of engagement*, *Contextual influence*, and *Potential obstacles*, detailed as follows:

4.2.1 Types of engagement: This theme includes the codes **Emotional response**; **Personal associations** (feeling of nostalgia, etc.); **Visual/aesthetic appreciation** (colours, techniques, etc.); **Symbolic association** (artwork's meaning, artist's intention); **Sense of place** (discovery of new/familiar places).

Emotional reactions were reported, such as *"This piece of street art had a quite profound impact on me (...) it made me feel grateful for the birds singing in the mess..."*.

However, the way they engaged with street art in response to the prompts varied. While some remained focused on analysing aesthetic impressions *"strokes are thick in proportion of each drawing"*, others went deeper into personal reflections *"the clouds... make me think of when I was a child..."*. The presumed author's intention was also considered *"is that rebellion or desperation?"*. Drawing was

reported as a positive strategy for engagement: *"When I was drawing, I concentrated more on the different aspects of the painting.(...) It made me pay attention to details more than just writing down words"*. Regarding response to prompts, the reactions were also diverse: *"I don't think the linear structure works so much for me. I'd like to be educated on those things so I am subconsciously aware but not in a 'this then this kind of way'"* or *"I don't want to repeat, but I see the point of it"*, referring to following guidance with prompts. Participants noted that adding context or background to the art made the experience more meaningful. Results emphasise an emotional payoff and a mood-lift effect. Furthermore, participants reported that the activity helped them to *"notice more, feel more engaged, and connect with the world"*.

4.2.2 Contextual influence. This theme addresses aspects like **Intentionality** (casual vs. intentional, routine or new observation); **Weather**; and **Urban life (presence of people, animals, etc.)**.

Participants noted that when asked to seek out street art, they started noting aspects previously ignored *"Even though I walked through the same city several times... I didn't notice the street art until I was specifically looking for it. Then I became very focused... It made me more attentive to the objects around me."*

External factors with potential to amplify or diminish the observation emerged, such as *"By the time we were leaving, there was a sunset, and I really liked how the sunlight was shining on the painting. That made me wonder if the artist also considered this aspect"*; or elements of an urban environment *"I told you that I was a bit scared of the rats. So it was the first graffiti and then the second one calmed me down..."*.

4.2.3 Potential obstacles. This theme includes the codes **Contextual distractions** (phone, cars, noise, etc.); **Social factors** (being alone, group interaction); and **Psychological state** (feeling busy, guilty, stressed, etc.).

Distractions were not only from the environment: *"I had to fight the distractions around me, mainly my phone haha and the street noise"*. One participant felt uncomfortable performing the activity in a public space alone: *"It was very awkward to be in a city full of people and then stare at a wall"*. Sharing the activity with someone else was perceived positively *"I liked it became a social and exploratory activity"*. Another participant noted: *We ended up discussing that some things you maybe discover together with someone... or that person thought of something completely different."*

4.2.4 Designing slow looking experiences. When asked in the interview about how they would design their own slow looking experiences, ideas did not necessarily touch the digital world. Instead, participants suggested promoting social gatherings, such as a meet-up with strangers to engage with selected areas of the city or particular pieces of street art. They appreciated the opportunity to reflect upon the observation and talk about it, sharing interpretations and stories. Other ideas included stickers placed at street art locations to prompt passers-by with questions about their own relationship with the art, or a deck of cards not with prompts but as conversation starters that encourage storytelling and creativity.

4.3 Discussion

In line with the literature, slow looking may take different routes, sometimes more artistic, or more personal and emotional or reflective, connecting with the context [14]. Guidance and background information about the artwork were valued by participants, though in different formats and at different stages of engagement with the practice. Guidance is needed especially to overcome scepticism or boredom in the journey. Framing slow looking as a group or social activity makes it feel more natural in public spaces. While building opportunities for connection, moments of reflective introspection are also needed. Overall, participants reported a positive mood shift with the practice. Although it is not a meditation exercise per se, both activities share similar characteristics related to mindfulness and relaxation, indicating potential to contribute to well-being and mental health [10]. Whilst these findings are encouraging for this exploratory study, the generalisability of the results to broader populations, including different age groups or urban contexts, remains to be established.

4.4 Design directions

Revisiting the resulting themes and codes from a design perspective yielded five general directions to guide discovery, contemplation and reflection when slow looking at street art. These directions aligns with Hallnäs and Redström's Slow Technology philosophy [5], shifting focus from efficient interaction towards pleasant, self-paced and reflective experiences that enhance the expressions and functionality of existing artifacts and spaces, and foster connections with both the environment and others.

1. *Reflective, but social.* Framing slow looking as a group or couple activity makes it feel less awkward in public spaces, while building shared moments of connection, though moments of introspection are also needed.

2. *Playful or mindfulness related.* Slow looking at street art should be proposed as a playful, non-pressuring activity rather than a task, especially in urban settings where focused observation can be more challenging. Both mindfulness and contemplation foster a state of openness and clarity, allowing people to move beyond automatic reactions and connect more thoughtfully with themselves and the world around them.

3. *Tailored prompts.* Prompts may follow different routes, artistic, personal, emotional, or reflective. Some people need invitations or triggers for curiosity, such as suggestions of places to go or alternative routes to take. Intentions behind the activity and previous knowledge of slow looking methods should also be considered. Background information is welcome, especially to move past the tipping point when scepticism or boredom can play a role. Also, prompts should address both the art and the surroundings, as they interplay.

4. *Creative process as engagement strategy.* Participants expressed a need of involving their creativity and/or integrating storytelling as the process pushes them beyond the surface-level observations. This may create opportunities for connecting with the art in a more personal way.

5. *Integrated, not intrusive.* Whilst digital solutions did not emerge spontaneously from participants' envisioned experiences, technology may remain relevant if designed to be social, ubiquitous, and environmentally integrated. Such an approach would enhance rather than distract from the contemplative experience, echoing slow technology's emphasis on promoting moments of reflection, contemplation, and mental rest [5].

5 Conclusion

In this exploratory study, we experimented with and involved eight participants in activities practising and documenting experiences of slow looking at street art. Though still limited to a specific target group, our findings suggest that slow looking at street art can bring valuable moments of well-being and connection with one's surroundings. Furthermore, it can foster social connections and facilitate bonding. A guide to slow looking at street art should consider social aspects, as well as address the different ways people want to structure the activity and manage distractions.

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A The cultural probe in detail

Participants of our study received a cultural probe kit, as illustrated in Fig. 4, to engage with the activities. The kit was handed in a silver envelope containing a notebook to be used as a diary, pages for annotation, colour pencils and stickers as crafting materials.



Figure 4: Kit as received by the participants

The consent form and information sheet were included in the kit. Some QR-codes with geolocations of street art spots as suggestions for the activities, as illustrated in Figure 5, were also provided.



Figure 5: Consent form, introductory page and link to geolocations with street art.

Participants were asked to set a timer to engage with the artwork, following instructions and prompts from the diary, which included prompts based on the slow looking strategies by Tishman [14]:

A. Colour, Shape, Line, Texture

- What colours do you see?
- What shapes do you see?
- What types of lines do you see?
- What textures do you see?

B. Open Inventories

- (1) Look at the street art slowly (suggestion: at least 30 seconds). Let your eyes wander.
- (2) List 10 words or phrases about anything you notice.
- (3) Repeat steps 1 and 2: look again, and add 10 more words or phrases to your list.
- (4) Now look at what is surrounding the artwork, slowly. (again, at least 30 seconds is suggested).
- (5) List 10 words or phrases about what you notice.

- (6) Repeat steps 4 and 5: look again, and add 10 more words or phrases to your list.

C. Physical Vantage Point

- Change your physical perspectives — far away or close up, above or below - see what changes.
- Can you step a few steps closer to your artwork, what new things do you notice?
- Now step as far as possible away from the artwork, what new things do you notice.
- Find a different angle to look from and observe what changes

D. Juxtaposition

- How can you compare the street art to something you see surrounding it?
- Describe its similarities and differences
- Describe how they interact

E. More than Words

- Now that you have given it some time to look at it, try to sketch it out. See if you can see beyond the objects at the centre of the attentional focus.

Participants documented their process through writing, drawing, or photos or collage. Once all exercises were completed, they wrote about their overall experience on the post-project reflection notes sheet. These pages of the cultural probe kit are illustrated in Fig. 6.



Figure 6: Diary pages with instructions (2), emotional connections guide (3), a reflection sheet (4), mindful drawing (5), and post-project reflections notes (6)



Figure 7: Diaries and other sheets part of the cultural probe returned by participants annotated for qualitative analysis

Over 2-3 weeks, participants engaged with the slow looking at street art activities using guided prompts, reflection exercises, and creative documentation methods. The material received was annotated for qualitative analysis as illustrated in Figure 7.